Project 1: Building an Edmunds Car Recommender System

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Course: DSC 201
Dataset: Structured Edmunds Car Reviews

This project develops and evaluates three practical recommender systems:

1. A **content-based recommender** that finds vehicles discussed with similar language.
2. A **collaborative recommender using SVD** that learns preferences from reviewer ratings.
3. A **hybrid recommender** that combines textual similarity with personalized SVD scores.

Dataset source: Structured Edmunds Car Reviews Dataset

1. Project Description

The dataset contains consumer reviews for vehicles from many manufacturers. Each record includes the review date, author name, full vehicle title, review title, review text, and a numerical rating from 1 to 5. The text fields provide content features, while the author–vehicle ratings provide user–item interactions.

The goal is to help a shopper discover relevant vehicles in two complementary ways. Content filtering answers, "Which vehicles are described similarly to this one?" Collaborative filtering answers, "Which vehicles fit this reviewer's learned preferences?" The hybrid model balances both signals so recommendations remain related to the selected vehicle while also being personalized.

To protect reviewer privacy, author names are normalized and replaced with anonymous IDs. Raw names are never displayed by the recommender functions.

2. Setup and Reproducibility

In [1]:
```
# Import numerical, data-management, visualization, and modeling libraries.
# Standard-library imports handle paths, text patterns, timing, warnings, and ZIP e
import os
import re
import time
import warnings
import zipfile
from pathlib import Path
```

```
# Keep Matplotlib's cache beside the notebook so restricted environments stay quiet
matplotlib_cache = Path(".matplotlib_cache")
matplotlib_cache.mkdir(exist_ok=True)
os.environ.setdefault("MPLCONFIGDIR", str(matplotlib_cache.resolve()))

# Third-party imports provide plotting, arrays/tables, sparse matrices, and ML mode
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import numpy as np
import pandas as pd
import seaborn as sns
from IPython.display import display
from scipy.sparse import csr_matrix
from sklearn.decomposition import TruncatedSVD
from sklearn.feature_extraction.text import TfidfVectorizer
from sklearn.metrics import mean_absolute_error, mean_squared_error

# Make every randomized operation reproducible.
RANDOM_STATE = 42
rng = np.random.default_rng(RANDOM_STATE)

# Improve table and chart readability without hiding important warnings globally.
pd.set_option("display.max_columns", 20)
pd.set_option("display.max_colwidth", 80)
sns.set_theme(style="whitegrid", context="notebook")
warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=FutureWarning)

print("Libraries loaded successfully.")
```

```
Libraries loaded successfully.
```

3. Locate and Load the Dataset

The next cell supports both the local project structure and Google Colab. In Colab, place either the extracted `raw` folder or the downloaded ZIP file at:

`My Drive/DSC201/Fall2026/Project_1/data/`

In [2]:

```
# Mount Google Drive only when the notebook is running inside Google Colab.
try:
    from google.colab import drive

    if not Path("/content/drive/MyDrive").exists():
        drive.mount("/content/drive")
except ImportError:
    # Normal local Python environments do not provide google.colab.
    pass


def locate_data_directory():
    '''Find 10+ manufacturer CSVs, extracting the Kaggle ZIP if necessary.'''
    # Check relative local paths first, followed by common Google Drive/Colab paths
    candidate_directories = [
        Path("../data/raw"),
        Path("data/raw"),
```

```
        Path("/content/drive/MyDrive/DSC201/Fall2026/Project_1/data/raw"),
        Path("/content/drive/MyDrive/Project_1/data/raw"),
        Path("/content/edmunds_data"),
    ]

    # Prefer an already extracted directory to avoid repeated work.
    for directory in candidate_directories:
        if directory.exists() and len(list(directory.glob("*.csv"))) >= 10:
            return directory.resolve()

    # If CSV files are not already extracted, look for the original Kaggle ZIP.
    candidate_archives = [
        Path("../data/structured_edmunds_car_reviews.zip"),
        Path("data/structured_edmunds_car_reviews.zip"),
        Path("/content/drive/MyDrive/DSC201/Fall2026/Project_1/data/structured_edmu
        Path("/content/drive/MyDrive/Project_1/data/structured_edmunds_car_reviews.
    ]

    # In Colab, extract the archive to the fast temporary runtime disk.
    for archive in candidate_archives:
        if archive.exists():
            extraction_directory = Path("/content/edmunds_data") if Path("/content"
            extraction_directory.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)
            with zipfile.ZipFile(archive) as zip_file:
                zip_file.extractall(extraction_directory)
            return extraction_directory.resolve()

    raise FileNotFoundError(
        "Dataset not found. Put the raw folder or Kaggle ZIP in "
        "My Drive/DSC201/Fall2026/Project_1/data/."
    )


# Resolve the data location once so every later cell uses the same source folder.
DATA_DIR = locate_data_directory()
csv_files = sorted(DATA_DIR.glob("*.csv"))
print(f"Dataset directory: {DATA_DIR}")
print(f"Manufacturer CSV files found: {len(csv_files)}")
```

```
Dataset directory: C:\UTampa\DSC201\Project_1\data\raw
Manufacturer CSV files found: 50
```

In [3]:

```
# Load each manufacturer file and retain its file name as the make source.
# Reading only the required columns reduces memory use and ignores accidental extra
expected_columns = [
    "Review_Date", "Author_Name", "Vehicle_Title",
    "Review_Title", "Review", "Rating"
]
frames = []
load_start = time.perf_counter()

# Each CSV represents one manufacturer, so process the files with the same schema.
for file_path in csv_files:
    manufacturer_frame = pd.read_csv(
        file_path,
        usecols=lambda column: column.strip() in expected_columns,
```

```
        low_memory=False,
    )
    manufacturer_frame.columns = manufacturer_frame.columns.str.strip()
    manufacturer_frame["Make_Source"] = file_path.stem
    frames.append(manufacturer_frame)

# Stack every manufacturer into one table and create a fresh continuous row index.
raw_reviews = pd.concat(frames, ignore_index=True)
load_seconds = time.perf_counter() - load_start

print(f"Loaded {len(raw_reviews):,} reviews in {load_seconds:.2f} seconds.")
print(f"Raw shape: {raw_reviews.shape}")
display(raw_reviews.head(3))
```

```
Loaded 226,931 reviews in 4.62 seconds.
Raw shape: (226931, 7)
```

	Review_Date	Author_Name	Vehicle_Title	Review_Title	Review	Rating	Make_Source
0	on 11/10/17 22:53 PM (PST)	V MEL	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Technology Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Good car	This Acura RLX has been a great vehicle for my family. The good part of th...	4.0	Acura
1	on 07/03/17 09:06 AM (PDT)	RLXer	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Technology Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	RLXer	Fast lots of room good gas mileage if you keep your foot off the accelerator	4.0	Acura
2	on 01/02/17 17:02 PM (PST)	Dpaprocki	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Advance Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Wish I had a better RLX story	2014 Acura RLX, with advanced package, purchased 3/14 at Pleasanton Acura•\...	1.0	Acura

4. Initial Data Audit

In [4]:
```
# Summarize types, missing values, duplicate rows, and the numerical rating field.
# This compact audit makes missingness and cardinality problems visible before clea
audit_table = pd.DataFrame({
    "data_type": raw_reviews.dtypes.astype(str),
    "missing_count": raw_reviews.isna().sum(),
    "missing_percent": (raw_reviews.isna().mean() * 100).round(2),
```

```
    "unique_values": raw_reviews.nunique(dropna=True),
})

print(f"Exact duplicate rows: {raw_reviews.duplicated().sum():,}")
display(audit_table)
display(raw_reviews["Rating"].describe().to_frame().T)
```

```
Exact duplicate rows: 804
```

	data_type	missing_count	missing_percent	unique_values
Review_Date	str	0	0.00	172687
Author_Name	str	1	0.00	165071
Vehicle_Title	str	0	0.00	29128
Review_Title	str	25	0.01	173131
Review	str	0	0.00	224472
Rating	float64	0	0.00	33
Make_Source	str	0	0.00	50

	count	mean	std	min	25%	50%	75%	max
Rating	226931.0	4.286309	0.922289	1.0	4.0	4.625	5.0	5.0

5. Data Cleaning and Feature Engineering

The cleaning workflow standardizes column names and text, validates ratings, removes duplicates and placeholder users, parses dates and model years, anonymizes reviewers, and creates features needed by all three models. Duplicate user–vehicle ratings are averaged later so every matrix cell represents one interaction.

In [5]:
```
# Rename columns to consistent snake_case names.
reviews = raw_reviews.rename(columns={
    "Review_Date": "review_date_raw",
    "Author_Name": "author_name",
    "Vehicle_Title": "vehicle_title",
    "Review_Title": "review_title",
    "Review": "review_text",
    "Rating": "rating",
    "Make_Source": "make_source",
}).copy()

# Preserve the starting row count so the cleaning impact can be reported clearly.
rows_initial = len(reviews)

# Convert the rating to numeric and retain only the documented 1–5 range.
reviews["rating"] = pd.to_numeric(reviews["rating"], errors="coerce")
reviews = reviews[reviews["rating"].between(1, 5)].copy()
```

```
# Standardize all important text columns and collapse repeated whitespace.
text_columns = ["author_name", "vehicle_title", "review_title", "review_text", "mak
# Apply the same HTML removal and whitespace normalization to every text field.
for column in text_columns:
    reviews[column] = (
        reviews[column]
        .fillna("")
        .astype(str)
        .str.replace(r"<[^>]+>", " ", regex=True)
        .str.replace(r"\s+", " ", regex=True)
        .str.strip()
    )

# Parse the timestamp after removing its leading word and timezone label.
date_text = (
    reviews["review_date_raw"]
    .fillna("")
    .astype(str)
    .str.replace(r"^\s*on\s+", "", regex=True, case=False)
    .str.replace(r"\s+(AM|PM)\s+\([A-Z]+\)$", "", regex=True)
)
# Invalid or unexpected date strings become NaT instead of stopping the workflow.
reviews["review_date"] = pd.to_datetime(
    date_text, format="%m/%d/%y %H:%M", errors="coerce"
)

# Derive manufacturer and model year from reliable source fields.
reviews["make"] = reviews["make_source"].str.replace("-", " ").str.title()
reviews["make"] = reviews["make"].replace({
    "Bmw": "BMW", "Gmc": "GMC", "Amgeneral": "AM General"
})
reviews["model_year"] = pd.to_numeric(
    reviews["vehicle_title"].str.extract(r"^(\d{4})", expand=False),
    errors="coerce",
).astype("Int64")

# Normalize author names for matching, but never expose them in model output.
reviews["author_key"] = reviews["author_name"].str.lower()
# Generic author labels cannot reliably represent individual users, so exclude them
placeholder_authors = {
    "", "anonymous", "unknown", "none", "n/a", "na",
    "a customer", "customer", "car owner", "owner", "edmunds user"
}
reviews = reviews[~reviews["author_key"].isin(placeholder_authors)].copy()

# A review requires a vehicle, useful text, and an identifiable interaction source.
reviews = reviews[
    reviews["vehicle_title"].ne("")
    & reviews["review_text"].ne("")
    & reviews["author_key"].ne("")
].copy()

# Remove duplicated scraped reviews before assigning anonymous IDs.
reviews = reviews.drop_duplicates(
    subset=["author_key", "vehicle_title", "review_text", "rating"]
).reset_index(drop=True)
```

```
# Assign stable anonymous IDs in sorted order for privacy and reproducibility.
# Sorting before ID assignment ensures the same raw data always produces the same I
unique_authors = sorted(reviews["author_key"].unique())
author_to_id = {author: f"U{number:06d}" for number, author in enumerate(unique_aut
reviews["user_id"] = reviews["author_key"].map(author_to_id)

# Combine the short headline with the full review for text modeling.
reviews["content_text"] = (
    reviews["review_title"] + " " + reviews["review_text"]
).str.strip()
reviews["review_word_count"] = reviews["review_text"].str.split().str.len()

# Summarize the row-level effect of all cleaning rules for transparent reporting.
cleaning_summary = pd.DataFrame({
    "stage": ["Raw rows", "Clean rows", "Rows removed"],
    "row_count": [rows_initial, len(reviews), rows_initial - len(reviews)],
})
display(cleaning_summary)
print(f"Anonymous users: {reviews['user_id'].nunique():,}")
print(f"Unique vehicle titles: {reviews['vehicle_title'].nunique():,}")
print(f"Parsed dates: {reviews['review_date'].notna().mean():.1%}")
```

	stage	row_count
0	Raw rows	226931
1	Clean rows	224444
2	Rows removed	2487

```
Anonymous users: 155,074
Unique vehicle titles: 29,039
Parsed dates: 100.0%
```

In [6]:
```
# Confirm that all model-critical fields are now complete and valid.
# A second audit verifies that fields required by the models survived cleaning.
cleaned_audit = pd.DataFrame({
    "missing": reviews[[
        "user_id", "vehicle_title", "content_text", "rating", "make"
    ]].isna().sum(),
    "unique": reviews[[
        "user_id", "vehicle_title", "content_text", "rating", "make"
    ]].nunique(),
})
display(cleaned_audit)

# Show only anonymized, model-relevant columns—not raw author names.
display(reviews[[
    "user_id", "vehicle_title", "make", "model_year",
    "rating", "review_word_count", "review_date"
]].head())
```

	missing	unique
user_id	0	155074
vehicle_title	0	29039
content_text	0	224406
rating	0	33
make	0	50

	user_id	vehicle_title	make	model_year	rating	review_word_count	review_date
0	U147327	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Technology Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Acura	2014	4.0	731	2017-11-10 22:53:00
1	U120419	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Technology Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Acura	2014	4.0	15	2017-07-03 09:06:00
2	U040387	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Advance Package 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Acura	2014	1.0	309	2017-01-02 17:02:00
3	U043049	2014 Acura RLX Sedan 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Acura	2014	4.0	53	2016-02-22 14:48:00
4	U133609	2014 Acura RLX Sedan Navigation 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 6A)	Acura	2014	3.0	85	2015-11-02 18:50:00

6. Exploratory Data Analysis

In [7]:
```
# Visualize rating behavior, manufacturer coverage, review length, and review years
# A 2-by-2 layout keeps four complementary dataset views in one figure.
fig, axes = plt.subplots(2, 2, figsize=(15, 10))

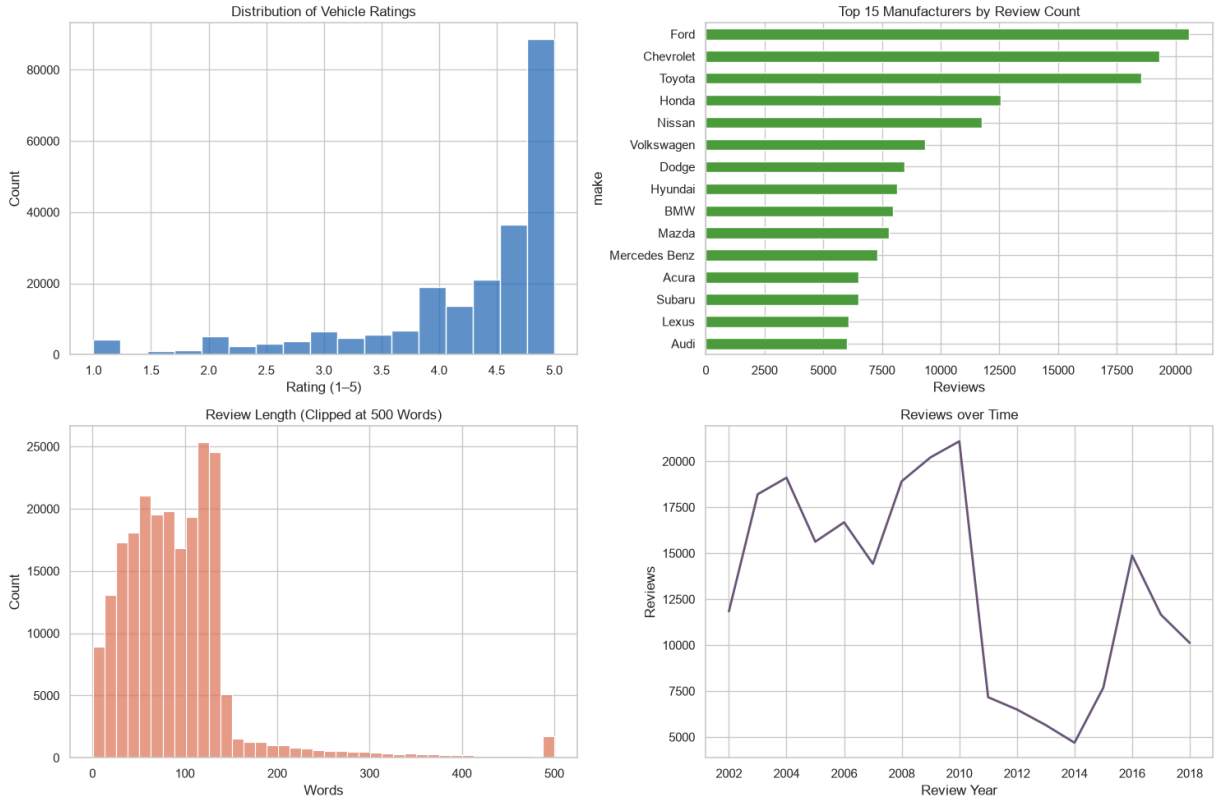
# Plot ratings to check whether the target is balanced or concentrated near 4–5 sta
sns.histplot(reviews["rating"], bins=17, ax=axes[0, 0], color="#2A6FBB")
axes[0, 0].set(title="Distribution of Vehicle Ratings", xlabel="Rating (1–5)")
```

```
# Manufacturer counts reveal popularity imbalance that can influence recommendation
top_makes = reviews["make"].value_counts().head(15).sort_values()
top_makes.plot(kind="barh", ax=axes[0, 1], color="#4E9F3D")
axes[0, 1].set(title="Top 15 Manufacturers by Review Count", xlabel="Reviews")

sns.histplot(
    reviews["review_word_count"].clip(upper=500), bins=40,
    ax=axes[1, 0], color="#E07A5F"
)
axes[1, 0].set(title="Review Length (Clipped at 500 Words)", xlabel="Words")

# Group parsed dates by year to show how dataset activity changes over time.
reviews_per_year = reviews.dropna(subset=["review_date"]).groupby(
    reviews["review_date"].dt.year
).size()
reviews_per_year.plot(ax=axes[1, 1], color="#6D597A", linewidth=2)
axes[1, 1].set(title="Reviews over Time", xlabel="Review Year", ylabel="Reviews")

plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()
```



In [8]:

```
# Examine interaction sparsity and identify well-supported, highly rated vehicles.
# User activity counts quantify the cold-start and sparsity challenge.
reviews_per_user = reviews.groupby("user_id").size()
# Aggregate ratings per vehicle so popularity is considered beside average score.
vehicle_summary = (
    reviews.groupby(["vehicle_title", "make"], as_index=False)
    .agg(average_rating=("rating", "mean"), review_count=("rating", "size"))
)

interaction_summary = pd.Series({
```

```
    "total_reviews": len(reviews),
    "unique_users": reviews["user_id"].nunique(),
    "unique_vehicles": reviews["vehicle_title"].nunique(),
    "users_with_2+_reviews": int((reviews_per_user >= 2).sum()),
    "median_reviews_per_user": reviews_per_user.median(),
    "maximum_reviews_by_one_user": reviews_per_user.max(),
}, name="value").to_frame()
display(interaction_summary)

print("Highest-rated vehicles with at least 25 reviews:")
display(
    vehicle_summary[vehicle_summary["review_count"] >= 25]
    .sort_values(["average_rating", "review_count"], ascending=False)
    .head(10)
    .round({"average_rating": 3})
)
```

	value
total_reviews	224444.0
unique_users	155074.0
unique_vehicles	29039.0
users_with_2+_reviews	15797.0
median_reviews_per_user	1.0
maximum_reviews_by_one_user	1132.0

```
Highest-rated vehicles with at least 25 reviews:
```

	vehicle_title	make	average_rating	review_count
13044	2007 Mercury Milan Sedan Premier 4dr Sedan (3.0L 6cyl 6A)	Mercury	4.929	28
10408	2006 BMW Z4 Convertible 3.0si 2dr Convertible (3.0L 6cyl 6M)	BMW	4.911	28
8065	2004 Lexus GS 300 Sedan 4dr Sedan (3.0L 6cyl 5A)	Lexus	4.910	32
17727	2010 Mercury Milan Hybrid Sedan 4dr Sedan (2.5L 4cyl gas/electric hybrid CVT)	Mercury	4.899	26
1280	1998 Lexus LS 400 Sedan 4dr Sedan	Lexus	4.895	43
3414	2001 Chevrolet Corvette Z06 Z06 2dr Coupe (5.7L 8cyl 6M)	Chevrolet	4.879	32
6591	2003 Mercedes-Benz SLK-Class Convertible SLK230 Kompressor 2dr Roadster (2.3...	Mercedes Benz	4.870	26
3947	2001 Lexus LS 430 Sedan 4dr Sedan (4.3L 8cyl 5A)	Lexus	4.868	54
3945	2001 Lexus GS 430 Sedan 4dr Sedan (4.3L 8cyl 5A)	Lexus	4.866	28
3214	2000 Toyota Camry Solara Coupe SLE V6 2dr Coupe	Toyota	4.865	26

7. Content-Based Recommender

Reviews are aggregated at the exact vehicle-title level. TF–IDF converts the combined review language into weighted unigram and bigram features. Cosine nearest neighbors then retrieve vehicles with the most similar discussion patterns. Requiring at least three reviews reduces noise from one-off items while retaining broad catalog coverage.

In [9]:
```
def build_review_corpus(text_series, max_reviews=12, characters_per_review=700):
    '''Join a bounded sample of reviews so popular cars do not dominate memory.'''
    # Truncation bounds RAM use and prevents vehicles with many long reviews domina
    return " ".join(
        text[:characters_per_review] for text in text_series.astype(str).head(max_r
    )


content_start = time.perf_counter()
# Collapse review-level rows into one document and one metadata row per vehicle.
item_content = (
    reviews.groupby("vehicle_title", as_index=False)
    .agg(
        make=("make", "first"),
        model_year=("model_year", "first"),
```

```
        average_rating=("rating", "mean"),
        review_count=("rating", "size"),
        review_corpus=("content_text", build_review_corpus),
    )
)
# Require three reviews so each vehicle profile contains more than a single opinion
item_content = item_content[item_content["review_count"] >= 3].reset_index(drop=Tru

# Limit the vocabulary for practical Colab memory use while retaining useful phrase
tfidf_vectorizer = TfidfVectorizer(
    stop_words="english",
    ngram_range=(1, 2),
    min_df=2,
    max_df=0.95,
    max_features=12_000,
    sublinear_tf=True,
    dtype=np.float32,
)
# fit_transform learns the vocabulary and returns a memory-efficient sparse matrix.
tfidf_matrix = tfidf_vectorizer.fit_transform(item_content["review_corpus"])

# Normalize lookup keys so capitalization or repeated spaces do not cause false mis
normalize_title = lambda value: re.sub(r"\s+", " ", str(value).strip().lower())
title_to_content_index = {
    normalize_title(title): index
    for index, title in enumerate(item_content["vehicle_title"])
}
content_fit_seconds = time.perf_counter() - content_start

def top_content_neighbors(query_index, n):
    '''Return top TF-IDF cosine neighbors using fast sparse multiplication.'''
    # TfidfVectorizer L2-normalizes rows, so their dot product equals cosine simila
    similarities = (tfidf_matrix @ tfidf_matrix[query_index].T).toarray().ravel()
    # Exclude the query itself; otherwise it would always rank first with similarit
    similarities[query_index] = -np.inf
    n = min(int(n), len(similarities) - 1)
    # argpartition finds the top n candidates faster than fully sorting the catalog
    candidate_indices = np.argpartition(-similarities, n - 1)[:n]
    ordered_indices = candidate_indices[np.argsort(-similarities[candidate_indices]
    return ordered_indices, similarities[ordered_indices]

print(f"Content catalog: {len(item_content):,} vehicles")
print(f"TF-IDF matrix shape: {tfidf_matrix.shape}")
print(f"TF-IDF nonzero values: {tfidf_matrix.nnz:,}")
print(f"Content model fit time: {content_fit_seconds:.2f} seconds")
```

```
Content catalog: 18,287 vehicles
TF-IDF matrix shape: (18287, 12000)
TF-IDF nonzero values: 5,236,968
Content model fit time: 61.25 seconds
```

In [10]:

```
def content_based_details(title, n=10):
    '''Return a detailed table of vehicles textually similar to the supplied title.
    # Convert the caller's title to the same normalized form used by the index.
    key = normalize_title(title)
    if key not in title_to_content_index:
```

```
        raise ValueError(
            "Vehicle title not found in the content catalog. Use an exact title fro
        )

    query_index = title_to_content_index[key]
    indices, similarities = top_content_neighbors(query_index, n)
    # Copy the matched metadata before attaching calculated similarity scores.
    result = item_content.iloc[indices].copy()
    result["content_similarity"] = similarities
    return result[[
        "vehicle_title", "make", "model_year", "average_rating",
        "review_count", "content_similarity"
    ]].reset_index(drop=True)


def content_based_recommender(title, n=10):
    '''Return a list containing n vehicle titles similar to the input title.'''
    return content_based_details(title, n)["vehicle_title"].tolist()


# Demonstrate the required function using the most-reviewed eligible vehicle.
demo_content_title = item_content.loc[item_content["review_count"].idxmax(), "vehic
print(f"Query vehicle: {demo_content_title}")
print("Recommended titles:")
print(content_based_recommender(demo_content_title, 5))
display(content_based_details(demo_content_title, 10).round(3))
```

```
Query vehicle: 2002 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)
Recommended titles:
['1999 Acura Integra Hatchback GS-R 2dr Hatchback', '2004 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2d
r Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)', '1998 Acura Integra Hatchback GS-R 2dr Hatchback', '200
2 Acura RSX Hatchback 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)', '2006 Acura RSX Hatchback 2dr H
atchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)']
```

	vehicle_title	make	model_year	average_rating	review_count	content_similarity
0	1999 Acura Integra Hatchback GS-R 2dr Hatchback	Acura	1999	4.759	14	0.209
1	2004 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)	Acura	2004	4.587	95	0.207
2	1998 Acura Integra Hatchback GS-R 2dr Hatchback	Acura	1998	4.846	13	0.202
3	2002 Acura RSX Hatchback 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Acura	2002	4.777	78	0.198
4	2006 Acura RSX Hatchback 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Acura	2006	4.538	13	0.196
5	2006 Acura TL Sedan 4dr Sedan w/Nav System (3.2L 6cyl 5A)	Acura	2006	4.667	39	0.194
6	2003 Acura RSX Hatchback 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Acura	2003	4.686	33	0.189
7	2003 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)	Acura	2003	4.687	95	0.189
8	2005 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)	Acura	2005	4.776	72	0.184
9	2006 Acura RSX Type-S Type-S 2dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 6M)	Acura	2006	4.796	46	0.180

In [11]:
```
# Evaluate content coherence: how often do top neighbors share the query manufactur
# Use the 100 best-supported vehicles so the coherence check is not driven by noise
evaluation_queries = (
    item_content.sort_values("review_count", ascending=False).head(100).index.to_nu
)
```

```
same_make_scores = []
close_year_scores = []
for query_index in evaluation_queries:
    neighbor_indices, _ = top_content_neighbors(query_index, 10)
    query_make = item_content.loc[query_index, "make"]
    query_year = item_content.loc[query_index, "model_year"]
    neighbor_rows = item_content.iloc[neighbor_indices]
    # Precision@10 is the fraction of ten neighbors satisfying the stated condition
    same_make_scores.append((neighbor_rows["make"] == query_make).mean())
    if pd.notna(query_year):
        close_year_scores.append(
            (neighbor_rows["model_year"].sub(query_year).abs() <= 3).mean()
        )

content_metrics = pd.DataFrame({
    "metric": ["Same-make precision@10", "Within-3-years precision@10"],
    "value": [np.mean(same_make_scores), np.mean(close_year_scores)],
})
display(content_metrics.round(3))
```

	metric	value
0	Same-make precision@10	0.703
1	Within-3-years precision@10	0.652

8. Collaborative Recommender Using SVD

Collaborative filtering requires repeat interactions. Duplicate user–vehicle ratings are averaged, and iterative k-core filtering retains users with at least three vehicles and vehicles with at least five users. One rating per user is held out for testing. Ratings are centered by each user's training mean before applying sparse truncated SVD.

In [12]:
```
# Average any duplicate ratings so each user-vehicle pair is represented once.
# Averaging repeated pairs produces exactly one rating for each matrix coordinate.
interactions = (
    reviews.groupby(["user_id", "vehicle_title"], as_index=False)
    .agg(rating=("rating", "mean"))
)

# Keep items supported by the content model so hybrid scores are always available.
interactions = interactions[
    interactions["vehicle_title"].isin(set(item_content["vehicle_title"]))
].copy()


def iterative_k_core(frame, min_user_items=3, min_item_users=5):
    '''Repeatedly remove sparse users/items until both support rules hold.'''
    # Copy the input so the original interaction table remains available for compar
    core = frame.copy()
    while True:
        previous_size = len(core)
```

```
        # transform repeats each group count on its rows, allowing direct Boolean f
        user_counts = core.groupby("user_id")["vehicle_title"].transform("size")
        core = core[user_counts >= min_user_items]
        item_counts = core.groupby("vehicle_title")["user_id"].transform("size")
        core = core[item_counts >= min_item_users]
        # Stop only when another full user/item pass removes no interactions.
        if len(core) == previous_size:
            return core.reset_index(drop=True)


core_interactions = iterative_k_core(interactions)

print(f"All unique user-vehicle interactions: {len(interactions):,}")
print(f"K-core interactions: {len(core_interactions):,}")
print(f"K-core users: {core_interactions['user_id'].nunique():,}")
print(f"K-core vehicles: {core_interactions['vehicle_title'].nunique():,}")
```

```
All unique user-vehicle interactions: 206,717
K-core interactions: 26,662
K-core users: 2,378
K-core vehicles: 3,384
```

In [13]:

```
# Randomly hold out one interaction per user for honest out-of-sample evaluation.
# Shuffle reproducibly so the held-out rating is not selected by the original row o
shuffled = core_interactions.sample(frac=1, random_state=RANDOM_STATE)
test_indices = shuffled.groupby("user_id", sort=False).head(1).index
test_interactions = core_interactions.loc[test_indices].copy()
train_interactions = core_interactions.drop(index=test_indices).copy()

# Remove rare test items that disappeared from the training fold.
trained_titles = set(train_interactions["vehicle_title"])
test_interactions = test_interactions[
    test_interactions["vehicle_title"].isin(trained_titles)
].copy()

# Map string identifiers to zero-based row/column positions in the sparse matrix.
user_ids = sorted(train_interactions["user_id"].unique())
item_titles = sorted(train_interactions["vehicle_title"].unique())
user_to_index = {user_id: index for index, user_id in enumerate(user_ids)}
item_to_index = {title: index for index, title in enumerate(item_titles)}

# Center each rating by that user's training mean to reduce rating-scale bias.
user_means = train_interactions.groupby("user_id")["rating"].mean()
train_interactions["centered_rating"] = (
    train_interactions["rating"] - train_interactions["user_id"].map(user_means)
)
train_rows = train_interactions["user_id"].map(user_to_index).to_numpy()
train_columns = train_interactions["vehicle_title"].map(item_to_index).to_numpy()

# CSR stores only observed centered ratings instead of allocating every missing cel
rating_matrix = csr_matrix(
    (train_interactions["centered_rating"], (train_rows, train_columns)),
    shape=(len(user_ids), len(item_titles)),
    dtype=np.float32,
)
```

```
# Learn latent preference factors without constructing a dense user-item matrix.
MAX_LATENT_FEATURES = 50
latent_features = min(MAX_LATENT_FEATURES, min(rating_matrix.shape) - 1)
svd_start = time.perf_counter()
svd_model = TruncatedSVD(
    n_components=latent_features,
    n_iter=10,
    random_state=RANDOM_STATE,
)
# Factorize R approximately as user_factors @ item_factors.T.
user_factors = svd_model.fit_transform(rating_matrix)
item_factors = svd_model.components_.T
svd_fit_seconds = time.perf_counter() - svd_start

# Density reports the observed fraction of all possible user-vehicle ratings.
matrix_density = rating_matrix.nnz / (rating_matrix.shape[0] * rating_matrix.shape[
print(f"Training matrix shape: {rating_matrix.shape}")
print(f"Matrix density: {matrix_density:.6%}")
print(f"Latent features: {latent_features}")
print(f"Explained variance: {svd_model.explained_variance_ratio_.sum():.3f}")
print(f"SVD fit time: {svd_fit_seconds:.2f} seconds")
```

```
Training matrix shape: (2378, 3384)
Matrix density: 0.301771%
Latent features: 50
Explained variance: 0.384
SVD fit time: 0.16 seconds
```

In [14]:

```
def predict_svd_rating(user_id, vehicle_title, k=None):
    '''Predict one rating, optionally using only the first k latent features.'''
    if user_id not in user_to_index or vehicle_title not in item_to_index:
        return np.nan
    # Clamp k to a valid range so experimental calls cannot exceed trained factors.
    used_features = latent_features if k is None else max(1, min(int(k), latent_fea
    user_index = user_to_index[user_id]
    item_index = item_to_index[vehicle_title]
    # The dot product estimates deviation from this user's average rating.
    residual = np.dot(
        user_factors[user_index, :used_features],
        item_factors[item_index, :used_features],
    )
    return float(np.clip(user_means[user_id] + residual, 1, 5))


# Compare SVD against global-mean and user-mean baselines on held-out ratings.
# Generate one prediction for every user-vehicle pair withheld from training.
test_predictions = np.array([
    predict_svd_rating(row.user_id, row.vehicle_title)
    for row in test_interactions.itertuples()
])
global_mean = train_interactions["rating"].mean()
global_predictions = np.full(len(test_interactions), global_mean)
user_mean_predictions = test_interactions["user_id"].map(user_means).to_numpy()
actual_ratings = test_interactions["rating"].to_numpy()

# RMSE penalizes large mistakes more; MAE reports the typical absolute error.
```

```
evaluation_results = pd.DataFrame([
    {
        "model": "Global mean baseline",
        "RMSE": np.sqrt(mean_squared_error(actual_ratings, global_predictions)),
        "MAE": mean_absolute_error(actual_ratings, global_predictions),
    },
    {
        "model": "User mean baseline",
        "RMSE": np.sqrt(mean_squared_error(actual_ratings, user_mean_predictions)),
        "MAE": mean_absolute_error(actual_ratings, user_mean_predictions),
    },
    {
        "model": f"Centered SVD ({latent_features} factors)",
        "RMSE": np.sqrt(mean_squared_error(actual_ratings, test_predictions)),
        "MAE": mean_absolute_error(actual_ratings, test_predictions),
    },
])
display(evaluation_results.round(4))

svd_rmse = evaluation_results.loc[
    evaluation_results["model"].str.startswith("Centered SVD"), "RMSE"
].iloc[0]
global_rmse = evaluation_results.loc[
    evaluation_results["model"] == "Global mean baseline", "RMSE"
].iloc[0]
if svd_rmse < global_rmse:
    print("SVD improves RMSE over the global-mean baseline on held-out ratings.")
else:
    print(
        "SVD does not beat the strong global-mean baseline on this very sparse data
        "It is retained because it supplies personalized ranking, while the result
        "reported honestly as a limitation."
    )
```

	model	RMSE	MAE
0	Global mean baseline	0.8933	0.6765
1	User mean baseline	0.9650	0.6936
2	Centered SVD (50 factors)	0.9647	0.6933

```
SVD does not beat the strong global-mean baseline on this very sparse dataset. It is
retained because it supplies personalized ranking, while the result is reported hone
stly as a limitation.
```

In [15]:
```
# Cache metadata and rated-item sets to make repeated recommendations fast.
item_metadata = item_content.set_index("vehicle_title")
seen_titles_by_user = (
    core_interactions.groupby("user_id")["vehicle_title"].agg(set).to_dict()
)


def collaborative_recommender(user_id, n=10):
    '''Return n unseen vehicle titles with the highest personalized SVD predictions
    if user_id not in user_to_index:
        raise ValueError("Unknown or too-sparse user_id. Choose an ID from core_int
```

```
    user_index = user_to_index[user_id]
    # Score every supported vehicle at once using vectorized matrix multiplication.
    scores = user_means[user_id] + user_factors[user_index] @ item_factors.T
    scores = np.clip(scores, 1, 5)
    seen_titles = seen_titles_by_user.get(user_id, set())

    # Traverse scores from highest to lowest while skipping already-rated vehicles.
    ranked_indices = np.argsort(scores)[::-1]
    recommendations = []
    for item_index in ranked_indices:
        title = item_titles[item_index]
        if title not in seen_titles:
            recommendations.append(title)
        if len(recommendations) == n:
            break
    return recommendations


def collaborative_details(user_id, n=10):
    '''Return collaborative recommendations with predicted rating and metadata.'''
    # Reuse the required list-returning function, then enrich those titles for anal
    titles = collaborative_recommender(user_id, n)
    result = item_metadata.loc[titles, [
        "make", "model_year", "average_rating", "review_count"
    ]].reset_index()
    result["predicted_rating"] = [
        predict_svd_rating(user_id, title) for title in titles
    ]
    return result.sort_values("predicted_rating", ascending=False).reset_index(drop


# Select a moderately active reviewer; this is more realistic than an extreme accou
core_user_counts = core_interactions["user_id"].value_counts()
realistic_demo_users = core_user_counts[
    core_user_counts.between(15, 30)
]
demo_user_id = realistic_demo_users.index[0]
print(f"Demonstration user: {demo_user_id}")
print(f"Known ratings: {len(seen_titles_by_user[demo_user_id])}")
print("Recommended titles:")
print(collaborative_recommender(demo_user_id, 5))
display(collaborative_details(demo_user_id, 10).round(3))
```

```
Demonstration user: U043212
Known ratings: 30
Recommended titles:
['2005 Nissan Maxima Sedan 3.5 SL 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 5A)', '2008 BMW X3 SUV 3.0si
4dr SUV AWD (3.0L 6cyl 6M)', '2014 Ford Focus Hatchback SE 4dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl
5M)', '2004 Chevrolet Aveo Hatchback 4dr Hatchback (1.6L 4cyl 5M)', '2012 Ford Fiest
a Hatchback SE 4dr Hatchback (1.6L 4cyl 5M)']
```

	vehicle_title	make	model_year	average_rating	review_count	predicted_rating
0	2005 Nissan Maxima Sedan 3.5 SL 4dr Sedan (3.5L 6cyl 5A)	Nissan	2005	3.661	28	4.553
1	2008 BMW X3 SUV 3.0si 4dr SUV AWD (3.0L 6cyl 6M)	BMW	2008	3.764	45	4.545
2	2014 Ford Focus Hatchback SE 4dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Ford	2014	1.995	53	4.544
3	2004 Chevrolet Aveo Hatchback 4dr Hatchback (1.6L 4cyl 5M)	Chevrolet	2004	3.556	29	4.544
4	2012 Ford Fiesta Hatchback SE 4dr Hatchback (1.6L 4cyl 5M)	Ford	2012	2.604	18	4.542
5	2006 Dodge Grand Caravan Minivan SXT 4dr Ext Minivan (3.8L 6cyl 4A)	Dodge	2006	3.943	55	4.540
6	2002 Ford Explorer SUV XLT 2WD 4dr SUV (4.0L 6cyl 5A)	Ford	2002	3.472	9	4.537
7	2005 Chevrolet Colorado Regular Cab 2dr Regular Cab Z85 Rwd SB (2.8L 4cyl 5M)	Chevrolet	2005	3.792	12	4.536
8	2007 GMC Yukon XL SUV Denali 4dr SUV AWD (6.2L 8cyl 6A)	GMC	2007	4.378	38	4.536
9	2009 Audi A4 Sedan 2.0T Premium 4dr Sedan (2.0L 4cyl Turbo CVT)	Audi	2009	3.294	20	4.536

9. Hybrid Recommender

The hybrid model first retrieves a content-similar candidate pool. It then predicts this user's rating for each candidate using the first `k` SVD latent features. Both signals are min–max normalized and combined. The default gives 55% weight to content relevance and 45% to collaborative preference. Already-rated vehicles are excluded.

In [16]:

```
def minmax_scale(values):
    '''Scale a numeric array to 0–1, handling constant arrays safely.'''
    # Convert Series/list inputs to a consistent floating-point NumPy array.
    values = np.asarray(values, dtype=float)
    value_range = values.max() - values.min()
    if value_range == 0:
        return np.ones_like(values)
    return (values - values.min()) / value_range


def hybrid_recommender(
    title,
    user_id,
    k=20,
    n_recommendations=10,
    content_weight=0.55,
    candidate_pool=100,
):
    '''Return personalized, content-relevant vehicles in an informative DataFrame.

    Parameters
    ----------
    title : str
        Exact vehicle title used as the content anchor.
    user_id : str
        Anonymous user identifier from the collaborative k-core.
    k : int
        Number of trained SVD latent features used in personalized scoring.
    n_recommendations : int
        Number of final rows returned.
    content_weight : float
        Weight assigned to cosine similarity; collaboration receives 1 - this value
    candidate_pool : int
        Number of content neighbors considered before personalization.
    '''
    if user_id not in user_to_index:
        raise ValueError("Unknown or too-sparse user_id. Choose an ID from core_int
    if not 0 <= content_weight <= 1:
        raise ValueError("content_weight must be between 0 and 1.")

    key = normalize_title(title)
    if key not in title_to_content_index:
        raise ValueError("Vehicle title not found in the content catalog.")

    # Stage 1: retrieve a broader pool using only textual relevance to the anchor c
```

```
    query_index = title_to_content_index[key]
    indices, similarities = top_content_neighbors(query_index, candidate_pool)
    candidates = item_content.iloc[indices].copy()
    candidates["content_similarity"] = similarities

    # Restrict to collaborative items and remove vehicles already rated by this use
    seen_titles = seen_titles_by_user.get(user_id, set())
    candidates = candidates[
        candidates["vehicle_title"].isin(item_to_index)
        & ~candidates["vehicle_title"].isin(seen_titles)
    ].copy()
    if candidates.empty:
        return pd.DataFrame()

    used_features = max(1, min(int(k), latent_features))
    user_index = user_to_index[user_id]
    candidate_indices = candidates["vehicle_title"].map(item_to_index).to_numpy()
    # Stage 2: score all remaining candidates for this user in one matrix operation
    residual_scores = (
        item_factors[candidate_indices, :used_features]
        @ user_factors[user_index, :used_features]
    )
    candidates["predicted_rating"] = np.clip(
        user_means[user_id] + residual_scores, 1, 5
    )

    # Put both signals on 0-1 scales so their weighted sum is meaningful.
    candidates["content_score_scaled"] = minmax_scale(candidates["content_similarit
    candidates["collaborative_score_scaled"] = minmax_scale(candidates["predicted_r
    candidates["hybrid_score"] = (
        content_weight * candidates["content_score_scaled"]
        + (1 - content_weight) * candidates["collaborative_score_scaled"]
    )

    # Return the strongest combined scores with metadata useful to a shopper.
    return (
        candidates.sort_values("hybrid_score", ascending=False)
        .head(n_recommendations)[[
            "vehicle_title", "make", "model_year", "average_rating",
            "review_count", "content_similarity", "predicted_rating", "hybrid_score
        ]]
        .reset_index(drop=True)
    )


# Anchor the hybrid example on this user's highest-rated content-eligible vehicle.
demo_user_history = core_interactions[
    core_interactions["user_id"] == demo_user_id
].sort_values("rating", ascending=False)
demo_hybrid_title = demo_user_history.iloc[0]["vehicle_title"]

print(f"Hybrid user: {demo_user_id}")
print(f"Anchor vehicle: {demo_hybrid_title}")
display(hybrid_recommender(demo_hybrid_title, demo_user_id, k=20).round(3))
```

Hybrid user: U043212
Anchor vehicle: 1997 Cadillac Catera Sedan 4dr Sedan

	vehicle_title	make	model_year	average_rating	review_count	content_similarity	pr
0	1999 Volkswagen Passat Sedan GLX V6 4dr Sedan	Volkswagen	1999	3.875	14	0.203	
1	1998 Cadillac Catera Sedan 4dr Sedan	Cadillac	1998	3.569	63	0.195	
2	1999 Chrysler Sebring Convertible JXi 2dr Convertible	Chrysler	1999	4.186	41	0.197	
3	2000 Mercedes-Benz M-Class SUV ML320 4dr SUV AWD	Mercedes Benz	2000	3.634	44	0.199	
4	2001 Cadillac Catera Sedan 4dr Sedan (3.0L 6cyl 4A)	Cadillac	2001	3.756	40	0.199	
5	2002 Volkswagen Jetta Sedan GLS 1.8T 4dr Sedan (1.8L 4cyl Turbo 5M)	Volkswagen	2002	3.300	25	0.194	
6	2002 Ford Focus Hatchback ZX5 4dr Hatchback (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Ford	2002	4.048	34	0.192	
7	1999 Volkswagen Jetta Sedan GL 4dr	Volkswagen	1999	3.500	18	0.192	

	vehicle_title	make	model_year	average_rating	review_count	content_similarity	pr
	Sedan (midyear)						
8	2003 Dodge Neon Sedan SE 4dr Sedan (2.0L 4cyl 5M)	Dodge	2003	4.098	14	0.176	
9	2000 GMC Jimmy SUV SLE 4dr SUV	GMC	2000	3.240	12	0.190	

10. Practicality, Efficiency, and Model Comparison

In [17]:

```
# Measure recommendation latency and summarize practical model characteristics.
# perf_counter provides a high-resolution elapsed-time measurement for each query.
start = time.perf_counter()
_ = content_based_recommender(demo_content_title, 10)
content_latency_ms = (time.perf_counter() - start) * 1000

start = time.perf_counter()
_ = collaborative_recommender(demo_user_id, 10)
collaborative_latency_ms = (time.perf_counter() - start) * 1000

start = time.perf_counter()
sample_hybrid_recommendations = hybrid_recommender(
    demo_hybrid_title, demo_user_id, k=20
)
hybrid_latency_ms = (time.perf_counter() - start) * 1000

# Compare speed together with qualitative strengths and limitations, not speed alon
efficiency_table = pd.DataFrame({
    "model": ["Content-based", "Collaborative SVD", "Hybrid"],
    "fit_seconds": [content_fit_seconds, svd_fit_seconds, np.nan],
    "sample_query_ms": [content_latency_ms, collaborative_latency_ms, hybrid_latenc
    "primary_strength": [
        "Explainable similarity and cold-start items",
        "Personalization from rating behavior",
        "Balances relevance and personalization",
    ],
    "primary_limitation": [
        "No user preference signal",
        "Needs repeat users and supported items",
        "Requires both models and weight selection",
    ],
})
display(efficiency_table.round(3))
```

	model	fit_seconds	sample_query_ms	primary_strength	primary_limitation
0	Content-based	61.247	91.023	Explainable similarity and cold-start items	No user preference signal
1	Collaborative SVD	0.158	0.563	Personalization from rating behavior	Needs repeat users and supported items
2	Hybrid	NaN	96.011	Balances relevance and personalization	Requires both models and weight selection

In [18]:
```
# Estimate collaborative recommendation coverage across a reproducible user sample.
# Sample without replacement so each evaluated user contributes once.
sampled_users = rng.choice(user_ids, size=min(50, len(user_ids)), replace=False)
recommended_titles = set()
for sampled_user in sampled_users:
    recommended_titles.update(collaborative_recommender(sampled_user, 10))

# Coverage is the fraction of the collaborative catalog appearing at least once.
coverage = len(recommended_titles) / len(item_titles)
practicality_metrics = pd.DataFrame({
    "metric": [
        "Collaborative catalog coverage (50 users, top 10)",
        "Content catalog vehicles",
        "Collaborative catalog vehicles",
        "Held-out collaborative ratings",
    ],
    "value": [coverage, len(item_content), len(item_titles), len(test_interactions)]
})
display(practicality_metrics)
```

	metric	value
0	Collaborative catalog coverage (50 users, top 10)	0.099586
1	Content catalog vehicles	18287.000000
2	Collaborative catalog vehicles	3384.000000
3	Held-out collaborative ratings	2378.000000

11. Save Reproducible Results

Small result tables are saved for inspection. The raw source files remain unchanged. In Colab, outputs are written to `/content/project_outputs`; locally they are written to the project's `outputs` folder.

In [19]:
```
# Choose a writable output directory for either local execution or Colab.
local_output_directory = Path("../outputs")
OUTPUT_DIR = (
    local_output_directory
    if local_output_directory.parent.exists()
    else Path("/content/project_outputs")
```

```
)
OUTPUT_DIR.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)

# Omit the large review corpus because the exported catalog is meant for inspection
item_content.drop(columns="review_corpus").to_csv(
    OUTPUT_DIR / "clean_vehicle_catalog.csv", index=False
)
# Save model metrics and a concrete hybrid example as lightweight reproducible arti
evaluation_results.to_csv(OUTPUT_DIR / "collaborative_metrics.csv", index=False)
sample_hybrid_recommendations.to_csv(
    OUTPUT_DIR / "sample_hybrid_recommendations.csv", index=False
)

print(f"Saved outputs to: {OUTPUT_DIR.resolve()}")
for output_file in sorted(OUTPUT_DIR.glob("*.csv")):
    print(f"- {output_file.name} ({output_file.stat().st_size / 1024:.1f} KB)")
```

```
Saved outputs to: C:\UTampa\DSC201\Project_1\outputs
- clean_vehicle_catalog.csv (1588.7 KB)
- collaborative_metrics.csv (0.2 KB)
- sample_hybrid_recommendations.csv (1.4 KB)
```

12. Conclusions

This project produced three complementary vehicle recommenders from real consumer review data. The content model uses review language to explain similarity and can serve items without repeat-user history. The centered sparse SVD model provides personalization while avoiding an impractical dense ratings matrix. The hybrid model limits candidates by content relevance and then re-ranks them using a chosen number of collaborative latent features.

The offline RMSE/MAE table should be interpreted alongside practical constraints. Review data are highly sparse, author names are not guaranteed to represent permanent accounts, and historical ratings can contain popularity and selection bias. The k-core improves model reliability but reduces coverage for new users and rare vehicles. In production, this system should add explicit onboarding preferences, monitor recommendation diversity, and retrain as new ratings arrive.

Required function interfaces completed

- `content_based_recommender(title, n)` → list of similar vehicle titles
- `collaborative_recommender(user_id, n)` → list of personalized vehicle titles
- `hybrid_recommender(title, user_id, k, ...)` → DataFrame of combined recommendations